FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Even in the colourful and diverse gallery of Indian leadership, Arvind Kejriwal, national convenor of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), is one of a kind. Not your typical neta, he emerged from within the wombs of the urban citizenry. Promising to answer their call for ending corrupt politics and ensuring pro-people governance, Kejriwal activated the 'aam aadmi' or common man as never before. He was closer to their needs, articulated their frustration with a rotten system, and spoke their everyday language. Stacked on top of his original image as an anti-corruption crusader that won him his first brief stint in office in 2013, Kejriwal soon positioned himself as the messiah of the lower middle class and saviour of the poor. Despite the best efforts of arch rivals Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Kejriwal led AAP to landslide wins in both the 2015 and 2020 Delhi assembly polls. The mint-new party won 67 and 62 seats, respectively, out of Delhi's total of 70, leaving the BJP with only three and eight seats (the Congress score was 0-0). These impressive wins were built on a remarkable set of welfarist giveaways for the underclass, meant to take care of their bare necessities. Among them, free electricity and water, vastly improved government schools and neighbourhood clinics. That pro-poor reputation still stands as the foundation of Kejriwal's electoral chances as he seeks a fourth term as chief minister.



February 24, 2020

Twelve years of immersion in politics have left their stains on Kejriwal. His persona now includes bruises earned from his bitter war with the BJP, which attacked his fortress from every flank. Its primary battle offensive: an ongoing money-laundering case filed against him by the Enforcement Directorate (ED). This led to a five-month jail stint for Kejriwal before the Supreme Court gave him bail. The ED also paraded to prison much of AAP's second rung on similar charges, including deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia, before they, too, got bail. Kejriwal finally gave up his office in September 2024 and made the Oxford-educated Atishi Marlena, who fits AAP's original prototype of the earnest activist-turned-politician, a stopgap CM. For all the stout denials (and lack of clinching prosecutable evidence till now), the controversy sullied his original USP as an anti-corruption messiah. The BJP kept at its image demolition project with the 'sheesh mahal' jibe, highlighting how Kejriwal's official residence was plushly renovated for a reported Rs 33.66 crore, at odds with his 'aam aadmi' self-projection. Its regular poaching, meanwhile, denuded the second and third rungs of AAP.

Kejriwal, though, is the ultimate Jack-in-the-box, as unputdownable as they come. Of late, he has led AAP to significant gains outside Delhi, taking Punjab by storm and even threatening to open up Gujarat and Goa. The AAP-BJP duel on the streets of Delhi, therefore, is about much more than 'half a state'. For Kejriwal, it's a battle of survival. His political future is at stake, as also of the party he built. Bail finds him back doing what he's best at: working the crowds with plainspeak that cuts through the political smog. And of course, raising freebie culture to all-new levels to retain his base among the underprivileged, who account for over half of Delhi's 34 million citizens. Kejriwal is promising to expand the ambit of AAP's freebies to include a cash dole of Rs 2,100 a month for poor women. Already beneficiaries of free bus rides, women constitute a crucial 45 per cent of the electorate, which support Kejriwal hopes to retain.

For the BJP, power in India's capital as a city-state has ironically eluded it for the past 27 years. Winning Delhi, therefore, is a prestige battle, so the party is throwing its entire big artillery to mortally injure its nemesis. Besides its top brass, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, addressing rallies, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) is diligently at work on a door-to-door campaign. Following on its recent path, the BJP has embraced the 'revdi' culture by seeking to wean away the poorer voter with an even bigger gift box than Kejriwal's, including a monthly Rs 2,500 in cash to women. The BJP is also aiming to maximise its natural hold over the middle class. Estimated at 45 per cent of the electorate, this segment tends to alternate between AAP for the assembly polls and the BJP for Lok Sabha elections. The middle class has expressed concerns over civic issues, such as the poor condition of roads, garbage clearance and the polluted Yamuna, and the BJP hopes to win them over by promising a better Delhi.

The third leg of the triangle, the Congress, is the smallest, but its exact length will be of crucial importance finally. The two INDIA partners are fighting separately. In 2020, AAP's continuing ingress on its turf left the Congress with just 4.2 per cent votes. Part of the BJP's strategy is ironically to ensure the Congress recovers its near-10 per cent vote from 2015 so that it dents AAP's vote share. But the Congress is also aware that an AAP demise in Delhi would pretty much write the obituary for the INDIA bloc, so it remains on the horns of a dilemma. Our cover story this week catches all the complex strategic games in play. At the centre of the chessboard stands Kejriwal, who rose to power as a common man but is now an uncommon politician fighting a do-or-die battle.

(Aroon Purie)